

02 / DEFINE

Clarity Before Commitment

Definition turns what we learned into a shared direction that Design, Engineering, QA and the business can act on without guessing.

5 MIN READ

“Documentation is useful. Shared understanding is the real deliverable.”

From insight to direction

Discovery can leave a team with interviews, analytics, screenshots, pain points, ideas and a long list of possibilities. None of that becomes a product simply because we understand it. At some point, someone has to turn the learning into a decision.

That is the job of definition. I think of it as the stage where ambiguity is converted into enough clarity for a team to commit. We decide what problem we are solving, who we are solving it for, what outcome we expect and what the first useful version of the solution should contain.

This is also where Product Management becomes very visible. A vague idea can survive a brainstorming session. It cannot survive a sprint without creating confusion, rework and conflicting expectations.

A PRD is not the product

I value PRDs, user stories, acceptance criteria, journeys and roadmaps because they give teams a common reference point. But I do not believe the quality of product thinking can be measured by the length of a document.

A forty-page PRD that Engineering interprets differently from Design has failed at its purpose. A concise document supported by a clear conversation can be much stronger if everyone leaves with the same understanding.

For me, the question is always: can the people building, testing and supporting this product explain what we are trying to achieve and why? If the answer is no, we are not ready simply because the document says ‘final’.

Definition is also prioritisation

Clarity is not only about describing a solution. It is also about deciding what not to do. Product teams almost always have more opportunities than capacity. Every ‘yes’ uses time that could have been spent somewhere else.

This is why I define scope deliberately. What is essential for the user to receive value? What can wait? What introduces too much complexity for the first release? What would be nice to have but does not meaningfully change the outcome?

Frameworks such as RICE, MoSCoW or impact-versus-effort can help structure those conversations, but they are not substitutes for judgement. A score can support a decision. It should not make the decision for the team.

Acceptance criteria: where clarity becomes testable

Acceptance criteria are one of my favourite parts of definition because they force an idea to become observable. ‘Make checkout easier’ is a goal. It is not yet something QA can validate or Engineering can confidently implement.

Good acceptance criteria describe what should happen in normal scenarios, error scenarios and important edge cases. They create a shared line between what is expected and what is open to interpretation.

They also expose gaps early. If we cannot explain what should happen when a payment fails, a connection drops or a user changes their mind halfway through a flow, the uncertainty has not disappeared. It has only been postponed until development or QA.

Knowing when the team is ready

I do not expect every question to be answered before development starts. That would create its own kind of waste. But the team should understand the problem, the intended outcome, the agreed scope, major constraints and how success will be evaluated.

The best definition work creates confidence without pretending certainty. It gives the team enough structure to move while leaving room for learning as technical and design realities become clearer.

That balance matters. Over-definition can make teams rigid. Under-definition makes them guess. Good Product Management lives somewhere in the middle.

Definition teardown: what must become clear

PROBLEM	What exactly are we solving, and what evidence supports it?
OUTCOME	What should become measurably better for the user or business?
SCOPE	What is included now, what is deliberately excluded and why?

EXPERIENCE

What should the user be able to do from start to finish?

CRITERIA

What must be true for the team to consider the work complete?

CONSTRAINTS

What technical, operational, regulatory or timing realities shape the solution?

SUCCESS

Which metric or signal will tell us that the change created value?

Definition is where product ideas stop being private interpretations and become a shared commitment. The clearer that commitment is, the less the team pays for confusion later.

Reflection prompts

- Can every function explain the problem in the same sentence?
- What have we deliberately left out of scope?
- What would QA need in order to test this without guessing?

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